

Practice Quiz: Agents (Philosophical Foundations)

Name: __ Date: __

Part A: Multiple Choice

1. The "self-model" in Active Inference is: A) A homunculus inside the brain B) A generative model the organism maintains about its own internal states C) A fixed, unchanging identity D) A social construct only
2. Active Inference's response to the hard problem of consciousness is best described as: A) Complete solution — consciousness is free energy minimization B) Process theory that explains the *structure* of experience but not its existence C) Denial that consciousness exists D) Irrelevant to the question
3. Agential minimalism in the FEP suggests: A) All agents are equal B) Agency comes in degrees — from simple homeostatic systems to self-conscious agents C) Only humans are agents D) Agency requires language
4. The compatibilist account of free will in Active Inference defines freedom as: A) Acting without any cause B) Acting according to one's own generative model rather than external coercion C) Random action selection D) Having no preferences
5. Personal identity over time is maintained through: A) A soul B) Structural continuity of the generative model and allostatic regulation C) External labels D) DNA alone
6. The dark room objection to agency asks: A) Why agents don't stay in comfortable rooms B) If everything minimizes free energy, does the concept of agency become trivially universal? C) Why rooms are dark D) How agents navigate darkness
7. Metzinger's self-model theory aligns with Active Inference because: A) Both deny any self exists B) Both treat the self as a virtual model generated by the brain, not a homunculus C) Both are based on Buddhism D) Both reject neuroscience

Part B: Essay Questions

1. "The self is nothing but a generative model." Evaluate this claim from the perspectives of (a) Hume's bundle theory, (b) Metzinger's self-model theory, and (c) Buddhist no-self. Which philosophical tradition does Active Inference most closely align with? (300 words)
2. Is a thermostat an agent? Use the FEP's graduated ontology to argue for a principled distinction between thermostats and organisms. What criteria distinguish mere homeostatic regulation from genuine agency? (300 words)
3. How does Active Inference reframe the free will debate? Is its compatibilist account satisfactory, or does it sidestep the real issue? Reference at least one classical position (hard determinism, libertarianism, or traditional compatibilism). (300 words)